And when it came to the Indica, Ratan was not willing to give up. It was his dream for India. His refrain was that if Indian engineers had the capability to put a rocket into space, there was no reason why the nation could not produce a car that it could call its own, says Kadle. ‘Making Indica was a huge step. He cradled it,’ says Wagh. Even when it came to rectifying the mistakes in the car, Ratan cut no corners. Customer meetings were held across India and the cars were repaired at no cost to the owners. It helped repose ‘their faith in the Tata brand’, says Dube.

In 2001, the Indica V2 was launched, and it was an instant success. ‘It stayed up on the top for four years. In one month, it had reached the top,’ said V. Sumantran, executive director and chief executive, passenger car business of Tata Motors from 2001 to 2005. All the previous glitches were removed. The next year, Tata Motors launched its first sedan, Indigo, built on the same platform. There was a steady surge in the demand both for the Indigo and the Indica V2. Ratan posed ‘challenges to a reservoir of talented young engineers’ and ‘Tata Motors’ technical brawn’ that ‘spans the gamut of the production process’ rose to the occasion, wrote the *Far Eastern Economic Review*.

The company also saw a revival in the demand for its commercial vehicles and trucks. Though in 2002–03, the segment’s market share had slightly dipped to 55.7 per cent from 56.1 per cent during the previous year, the number of vehicles sold had increased by more than 28 per cent. With the increasing revenues from the passenger segment, in 2003, the company surpassed its previous record of highest turnover in 1997.

It was a ‘remarkable turnaround’, wrote the same business newspaper that had voiced doubts about the future of the company. The editorial added, ‘The question we posed rhetorically in June 2001 has been answered. And convincingly.’ TELCO had indeed done a TISCO.

While consolidating its position in the Indian market, TELCO simultaneously moved on the global front. As a part of the overall strategy to increase its presence abroad, the company entered into a distribution agreement with the Rover Group for the Tata Indica in the UK. This was when it changed its name to Tata Motors Limited, in July 2003. The same year it signed a memorandum of association to acquire Daewoo Commercial Vehicles, South Korea’s second-largest truck maker at the time. It was a decision driven to augment the capability of Tata Motors, as the defunct South Korean company produced heavier trucks than any in